

productions in China last year and amassed 50.44 billion yuan ($6.9 billion), surpassing even theatrical revenues. Globally, the format is projected to be valued at more than $10 billion by 2030.

India, too, is discovering a ravenous appetite for the genre. While they have access to many foreign apps, with shows dubbed in English and other Indian languages, indigenous apps/ studios are coming up too, producing their own shows and tapping the local market. "From movies to groceries, everything is accessible on the phone now," says Hansraj. "Your phone is the new silver screen. So, why would you not want to be on it?" If the name of the game is user retention at any cost, especially at a time of diminishing attention spans, micro dramas seem to have cracked open a gaping hole in the market created by TikTok, YouTube Shorts and Instagram Reels. Now the plot is about twists and turns—as fast as you can get them.

India Boards the Bandwagon

What Mumbai's Andheri is to Bollywood, with all its film studios and casting offices, Bengaluru's HSR Layout is to the micro drama industry. This tech district has become a hub for a host of start-up streaming platforms like KukuTV, Viralo and DashVerse, which are betting big on the fast-evolving format. Encouraged by venture capitalist funds, they keep the money going while the writing and shooting happens in Mumbai, usually with newbies, TV veterans, and short/ ad filmmakers. The result? Videos churned out almost daily. A standard production cycle takes three weeks at most, from ideation to release, and actors are paid right after the shoot. "Everything is super instant," says Hansraj.



"There are times when you want the depth of a long-form show or the scale of a movie, and there are other times when you only have a few minutes, but still want to be entertained"

AMOGH DUSAD, *Director & Head of Content, Amazon MX Player*

What makes this spot attractive for upcoming studios is its proximity to India's tech talent, because a seamless experience on the apps is almost essential to their success. With UPI payments ubiquitous now, what these platforms rely on is a pay-per-episode or subscription model—the goal is to make your passage from downloading the app to starting an episode lightning-fast. "A micro drama offers instant gratification," says Saurabh Pandey, founder and CEO of StoryTV, an Indian app for micro dramas. "You like commerce coming into your home in 10 minutes and you like a

WHAT IS A MICRO DRAMA?

The traits that set it apart from a traditional soap opera

- **Mobile-first format:** It is bite-sized storytelling experienced vertically, like YouTube Shorts or Instagram Reels
- **Entertainment on the go:** Each episode is just one to three minutes long and ends with a cliffhanger. A micro-drama usually runs for up to 40-80 episodes
- **Small budgets:** The average production budget runs up to Rs 25 lakh, with smaller companies developing one in under Rs 10 lakh
- **Quick production cycle:** Ideation, shooting and release are all wrapped up in no more than three weeks
- **Popular genres:** Genres that lend themselves well to the medium include romances, rags-to-riches tales and revenge dramas
- **Speedy sign-ups:** After trial episodes, annual subscriptions vary from Rs 899 (StoryTV) to Rs 4,999 (DramaBox) to Rs 10,100 (ReelShort)